

Alchemy in art

Two major Renaissance preoccupations, art and alchemy, often came together during the period. Alchemy was a gift for artists—a colorful, exciting, magical topic, filled with exotic symbols such as dragons and majestic birds. All kinds of images of alchemy appear in Renaissance paintings, from the scholarly and allegorical to the workaday.

The symbolic, intricate works shown here come from *Splendor solis*, a 16th-century illuminated alchemical manuscript rich with color and gold. The text was believed to be by the famed (but most likely mythical) Renaissance alchemist Salomon Trismosin. The name of the artist—or artists—who painted the images is still a matter of debate.

Splendor solis details the adventures of an alchemist seeking the prized Philosopher's Stone. Recurring numbers, particularly the number seven, were important in alchemy: the images shown here link seven principal astrological deities—seen at the top of each image—with seven major alchemical processes. The cosmic deities depicted are Saturn (top far left), Jupiter (top left), Mars (center left), the Sun (bottom left), Mercury (center), Venus (top right), and the Moon (bottom right). Each flask contains a classic symbol of a stage in the alchemical process: the peacock represents a stage that produces multiple colors, while the white queen (center) and red king (bottom right) stand for aspects that must unite to produce alchemy's goal: perfection.

“Therewith I tinged three
metals into fine Gold ...”

SALOMON TRISMOSIN (ATTRIB.), *SPLENDOR SOLIS*, 1500s

